



AP PHOTO

Blockbusters DEFY BORDERS

The world is far more accepting and aware of our cinema than ever before. Indian stories will find echoes elsewhere and our exotic nature will be appreciated for its authenticity.

— By **KARAN JOHAR**

If there was any proof needed that Indian entertainment is in the throes of change, you need only to look at the box-office gross of *Chak De! India*, *Taare Zameen Par* and *Partner*. All three vastly different movies earned almost the same revenue at the box-office. Technology has changed so much in the past two years, allowing audiences access to so much more information that they have evolved beyond the imagination of most filmmakers and certainly most of what is popularly known as the film trade. For the first time,

for over a decade, Indian filmmakers have the same sensibility as their audience. And yet, from the first assistant director to the writer of a film, almost everyone wants to make the movies they themselves want to watch, not what they think will be popular. The mantras I grew up with in the '80s and '90s when my father produced films—there should be a buffer space after the interval to allow for viewers to come back from the food stall, there shouldn't be a slow song before the climax, there should be an item song in the first half and another in the second, and there should also be a sympathetic Muslim character to get in Muslim audiences—have changed.

Filmmakers are, for good or bad, being more honest with themselves. And therein lies our uniqueness and our vitality as an industry